

Empirical Test of the Five Love Languages

RYAN DOBSON

2ND YEAR PHD STUDENT, EVOLUTION & SOCIETY AREA

MENTOR: GEOFFREY MILLER

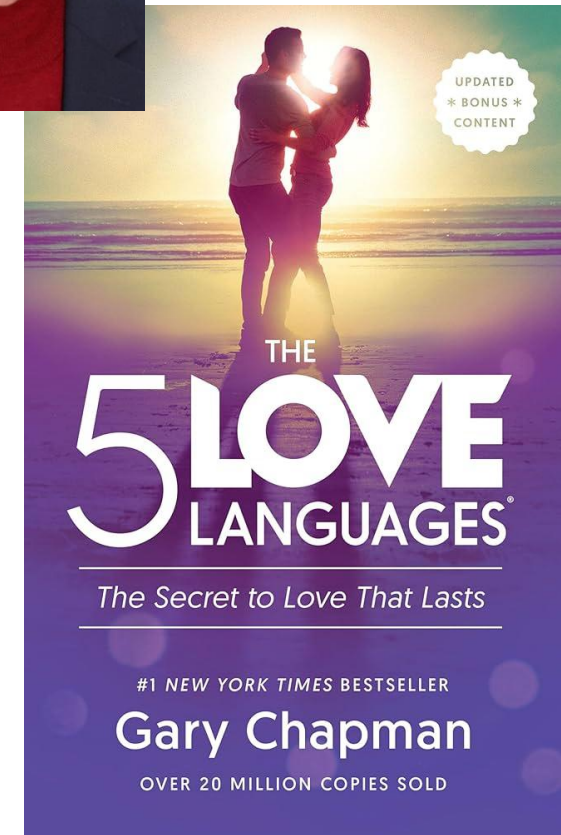


Project conception



The Five Love Languages by Gary Chapman (1992, 2024)

- Baptist pastor (b. 1938) who counselled many couples
- Translated into 50 languages
- Sold over 20 million copies worldwide
- Hashtag #lovelanguages has more than 500 million views on TikTok
- Applied in relationship counseling and government initiatives
- \$20 million relationship education program subsidized by the Australian government (as cited in Bunt & Hazelwood, 2017)





ACTS OF SERVICE

Run an errand for your partner, cook a meal, complete a household chore



GIFTS

Give thoughtful and meaningful gifts of any size, without an occasion



PHYSICAL TOUCH

Hug, kiss, hold hands



QUALITY TIME

Give your partner undivided attention via exclusive time together



WORDS OF AFFIRMATION

Offer verbal compliments and words of appreciation

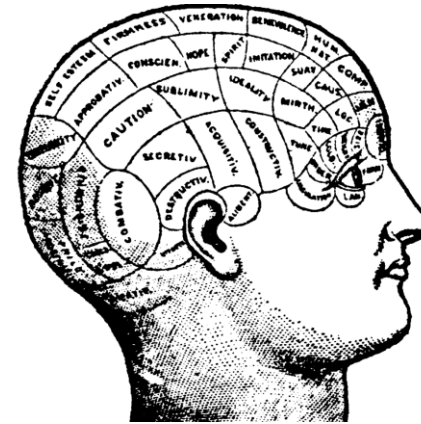
Chapman's Main Claims:

- People have a primary love language that they prefer to receive from their romantic partner.
- If people can “speak their partner’s primary love language,” their relationship will improve.

What do we know about Chapman's theory?

- Empirical tests (c. 10 weak empirical studies) have not supported Chapman's claims (as reviewed by Impett et al., 2024)
- Looks like pseudoscience (vague, unfalsifiable, based on anecdotes & clinical experience) (Lilienfeld et al., 2015)

DEBUNKED



An untested assumption and a new 'love language'

- Expressing vs. Receiving Love
- Sexual activity



What did participants do?

- 29 items expression (4-6 items per LL)
 - To what extent would each behavior be an expression of your love?

Really listening to my partner.

- ☐ Not at all an expression of my love
- ☐ A little bit of an expression of my love
- ☐ Somewhat of an expression of my love
- ☐ Very much an expression of my love
- ☐ Extremely an expression of my love



Continued...

- Same 29 items reception (reworded for format)
 - To what extent would each behavior be an expression of your partner's love for you?

Randomly getting me a small gift.

- ☐ Not at all an expression of their love for me
- ☐ A little bit of an expression of their love for me
- ☐ Somewhat of an expression of their love for me
- ☐ Very much an expression of their love for me
- ☐ Extremely an expression of their love for me

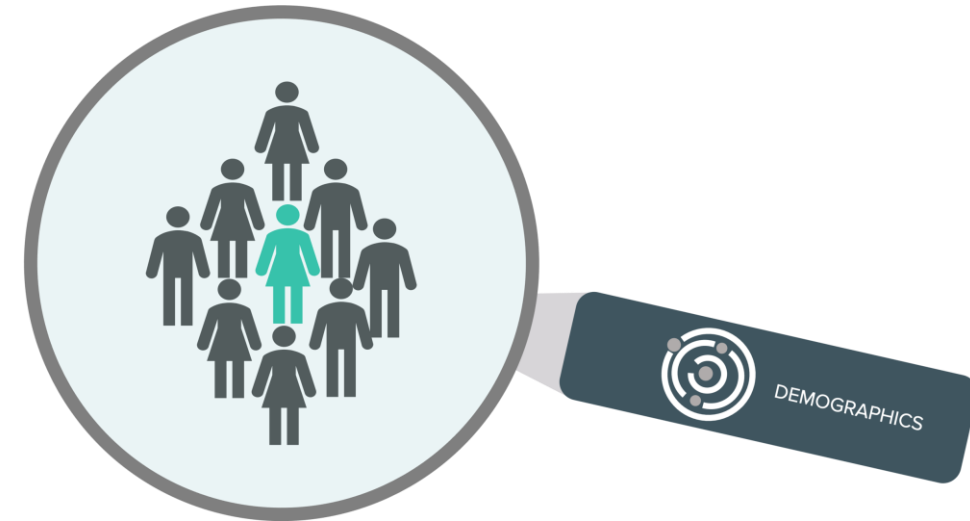


Demographics

- N = 740
 - 601 from X (Twitter)
 - 139 from SONA
- 55% Male
- 77% heterosexual
- $M_{age} = 34.3$
- $SD_{age} = 12.1$

Relationship Status:

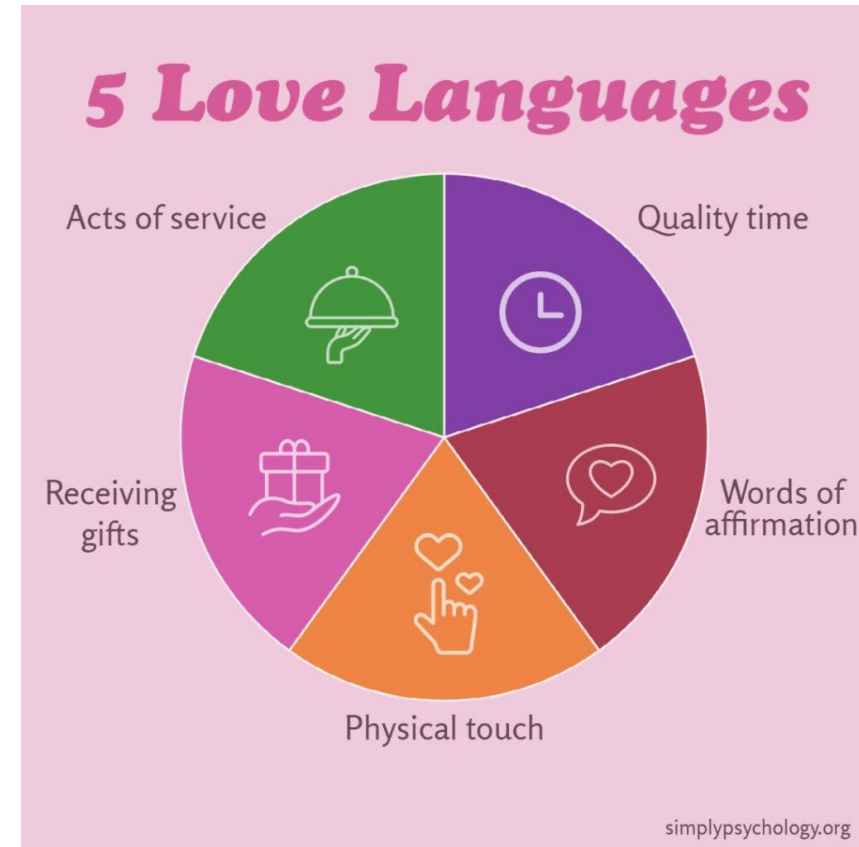
- 61% exclusive relationship
- 29% single
- 10% alternative relationship styles
 - (poly, swingers, etc.)



Several data quality controls and checks were used (e.g., < 4 minutes, Captcha verification, matching age with reported birth year).

Chapman's Hypothesized Structure

- Five factor structure had inadequate fit in both the expression and reception formats
- Single factor solution also fit poorly in both formats



Two 'Love Languages' ?

Relational Nurturing and Investment (25 items)

- Randomly getting me a small gift
- Making a special effort to spend time with me
- Really listening to me
- Spending their free time with me
- Hugging me
- Helping me keep things cleaned up
- Telling me that they love me

Pleasing Me Sexually (3 items)

- Performing oral sex on me
- Having sex with me
- Performing sexual acts for me

Five 'Love Languages' ?

Time and Attention Investment (7 items)

- Giving my full attention to my partner when I see them
- Having a quality conversation

Simple Displays of Affection (7 items)

- Holding my partner's hand
- Telling my partner, I miss them

Thoughtful Acts (4 items)

- Giving them a thoughtful birthday gift
- Writing sweet notes to my partner

Acts of service (3 items)

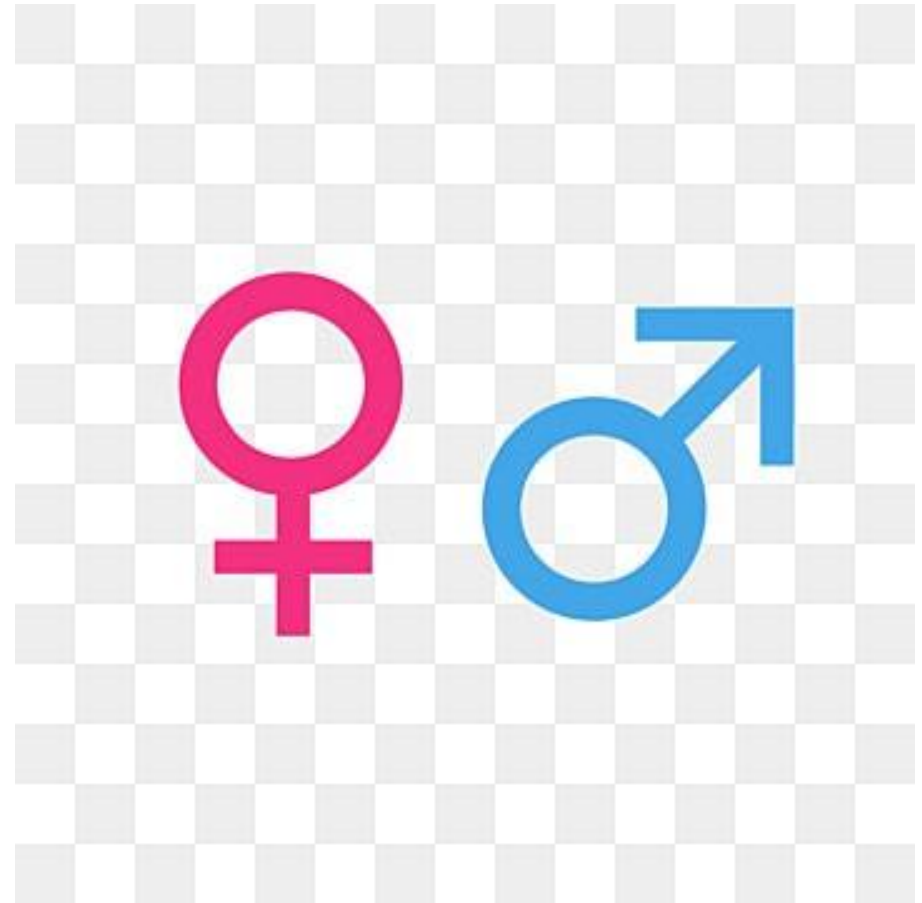
- Running errands for my partner
- Helping my partner keep things cleaned up

Pleasing Me Sexually (3 items)

- Having sex with my partner
- Performing sexual acts for my partner

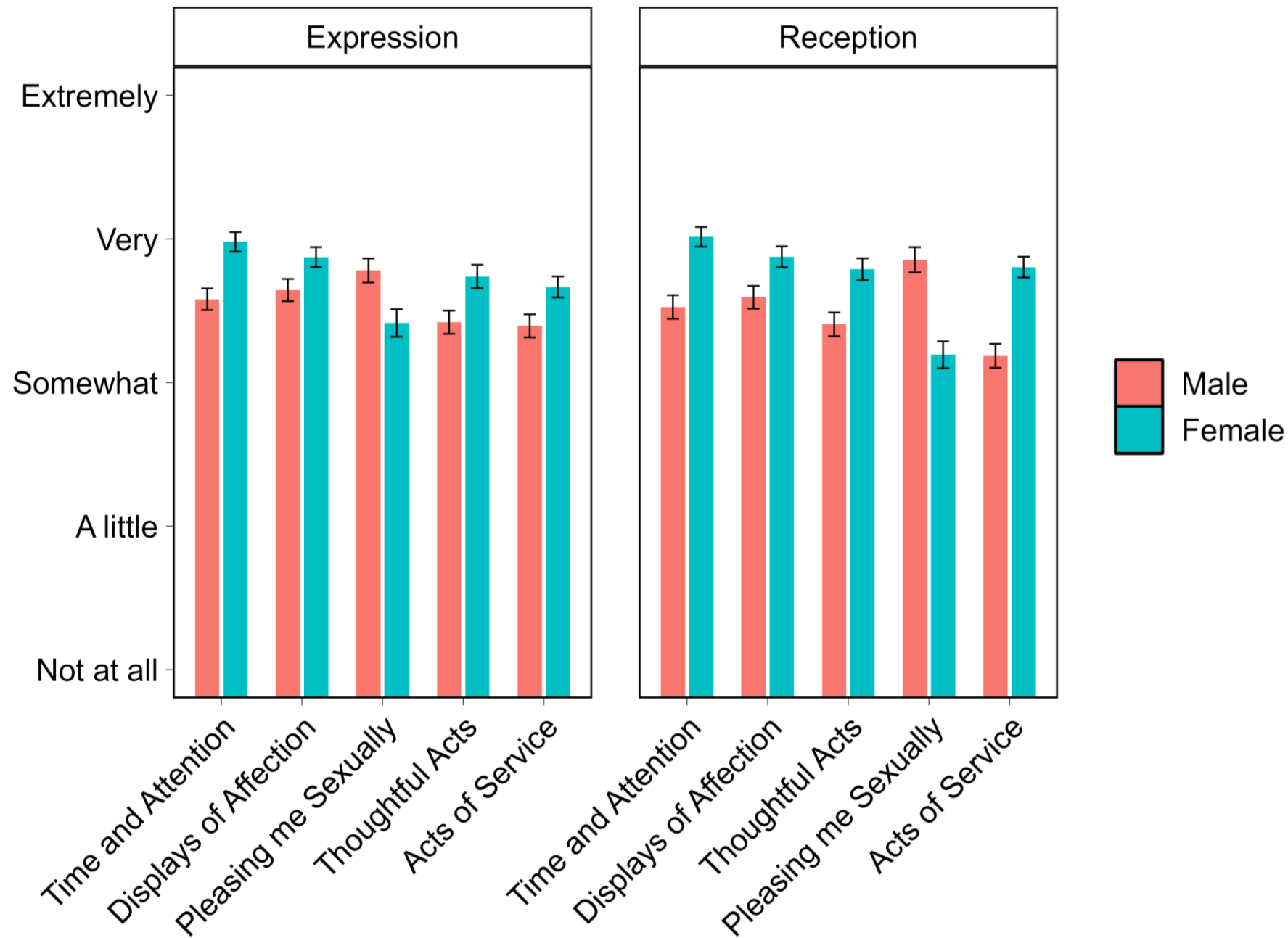
Did results differ by participant sex?

- Running separate analyses for men and women found 6 Love Languages for men and women.
- Physical touch and words of affirmation were separate
- Largely similar across men and women



How many love languages are there?

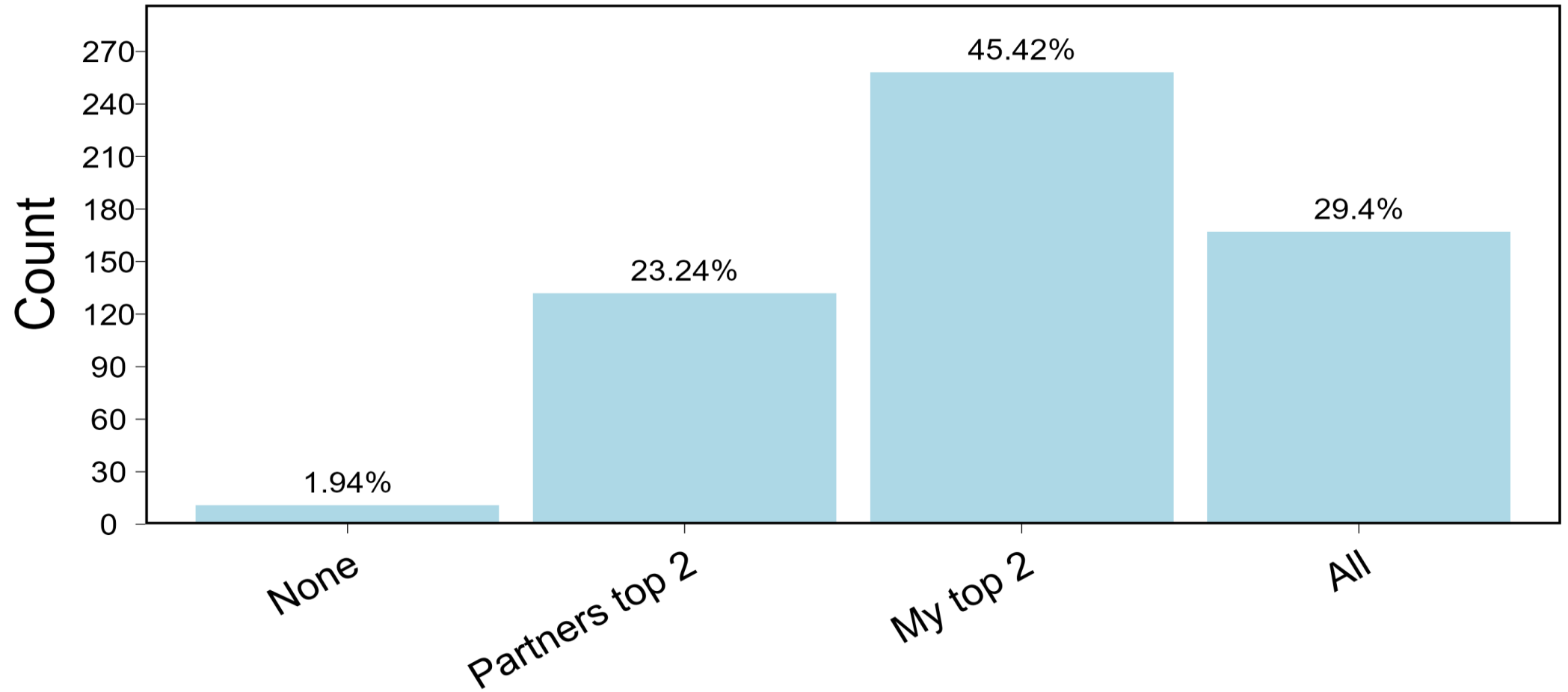
- The structure is similar to Chapman's love languages.
 - ~5 love languages isn't a bad model?
- The Reception and Expression structures are consistent with each other.
- "Pleasing me sexually" is a distinct, new 'love language.'
- There is somewhat of a general 'love language,' where some people find everything more loving
 - Could in part be caused by method effects (e.g., some people use more extreme ends of the response scale)
- The structure is relatively complex, most questions cut across multiple love languages (e.g., 'Taking time out of their day to help me' represents both Acts of Service and Quality Time)



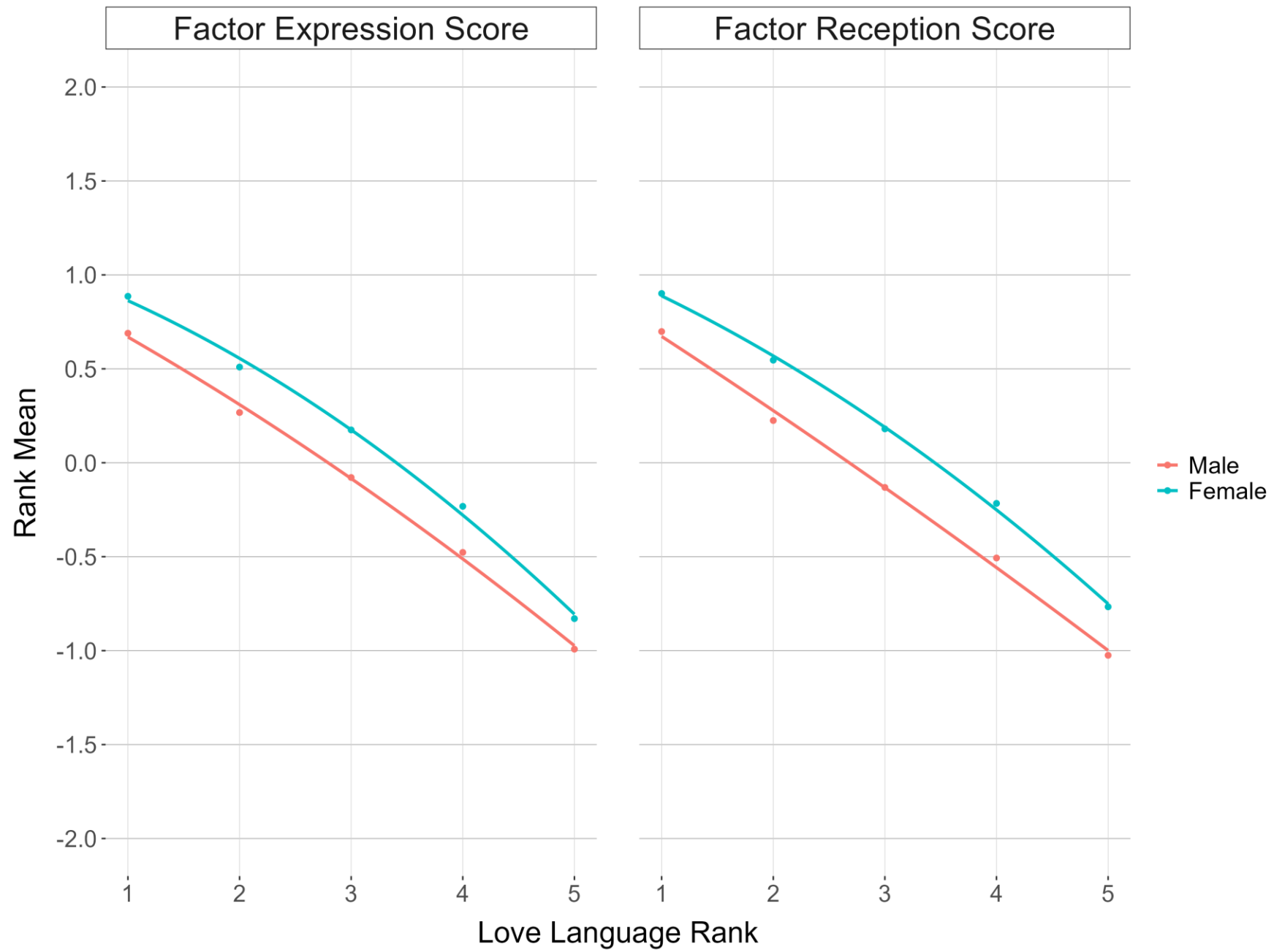
Distribution of Ranks for Reception and Expression by Sex



If you could choose what love languages your partner expressed to you, which circumstance would make you most satisfied?



N = 568; NA = 172



Thank you!

